FOOTPRINTS WITHOUT FEET

H.G. Wells

Class 10 English
Master Revision File

CHAPTER THEME:
A scientific marvel corrupted by human greed. Does ultimate power inevitably lead to lawlessness?

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The Mystery in Mid-Winter London

CASE NOTES

- Two bewildered boys spot fresh muddy imprints of bare feet on the steps of a house.
- A remarkable sight: A fresh footmark appears from nowhere!
- The boys follow the prints in fascination until they grow faint and disappear completely.

KEY INSIGHT:
The boys were unknowingly tracking a scientist who had just made the human body completely invisible.

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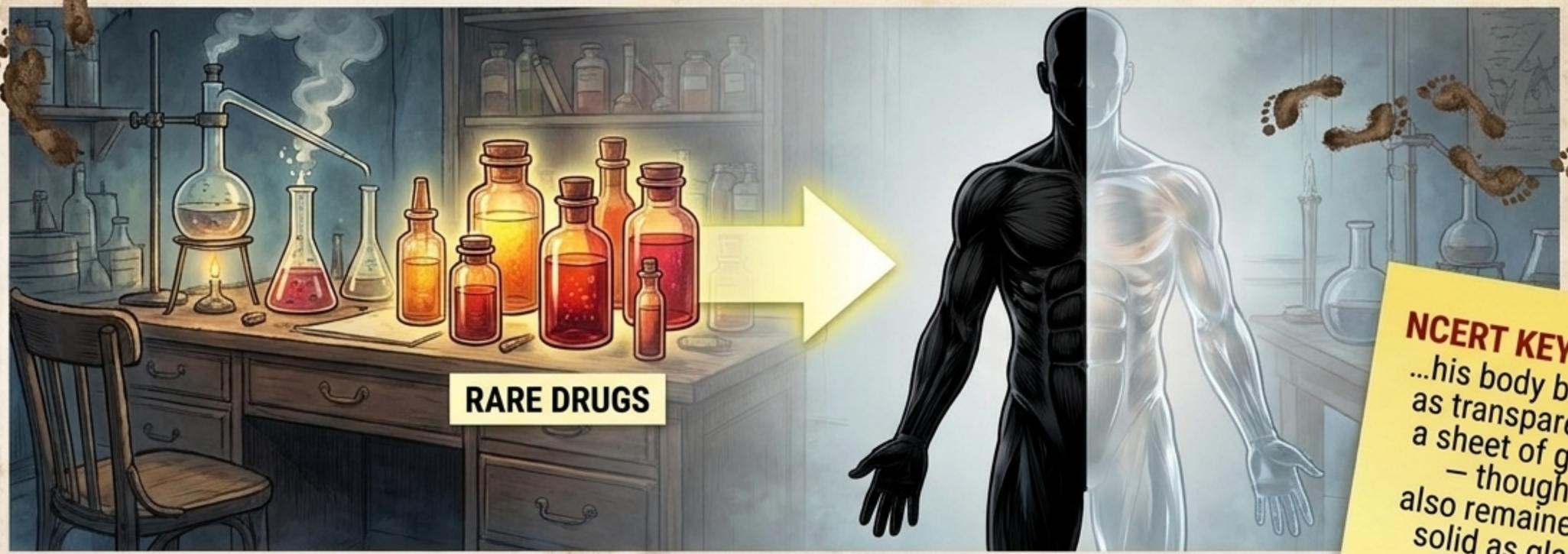
Griffin: The Brilliant Scientist

1.
Conducts countless experiments to prove human invisibility.

2.
Swallows a specific combination of rare drugs.

3.
His body undergoes a radical transformation.



NCERT KEYWORD:
...his body became as transparent as a sheet of glass — though it also remained as solid as glass.

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The Lawless Persona

Though brilliant, Griffin is fundamentally a **lawless person**.

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The London Store Episode

Evening Closing:
Slips into a large London store to escape the bitter chill.

The Feast:
Breaks open boxes. Finds warm clothes, overcoat, wide-brimmed hat. Eats cold meat, coffee, sweets, and wine from the grocery.

Morning Panic:
Assistants arrive. Griffin panics, runs, and is forced to strip off his newly found clothes to become invisible and escape the chase.

The Mistake:
Sleeps on a pile of quilts but fails to wake up before the store opens.

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Drury Lane: The Theatrical Disguise

Large hat

Bandages round the forehead

Dark glasses

False nose

Big bushy side-whiskers

Warning Label

THE ESCALATION: Griffin callously attacked the shopkeeper from behind and robbed him of all his money to fund his escape from crowded London.

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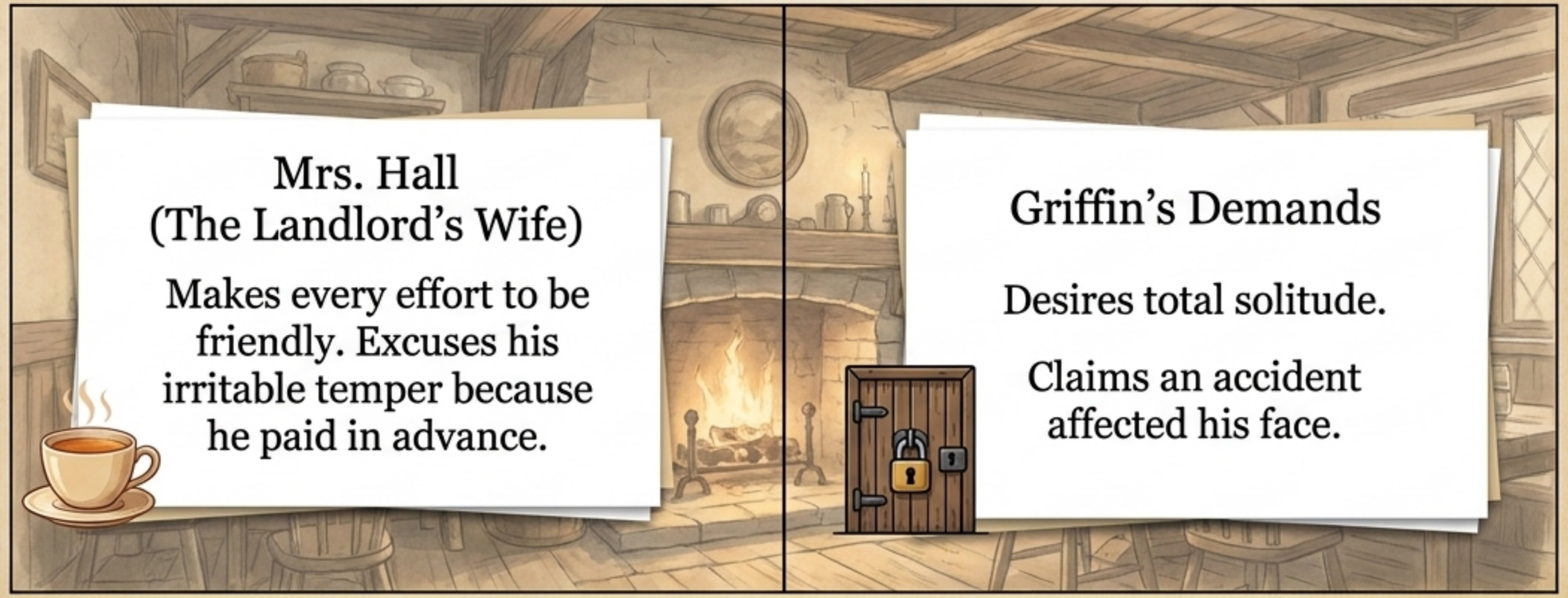
Arrival at Iping Village

Context: Takes a train to Iping in winter—an unusual event that sets tongues wagging.



Mrs. Hall (The Landlord's Wife)

Makes every effort to be friendly. Excuses his irritable temper because he paid in advance.

Griffin's Demands

Desires total solitude.

Claims an accident affected his face.

VILLAGE CONSENSUS: The locals categorize him as an eccentric scientist.

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The Clergyman's Burglary

THE SETUP: Griffin's stolen money runs out; he falsely claims a cheque is arriving.

1. Clergyman and wife awakened by noises in the early morning.
2. Hear the unmistakable chink of money being taken from the desk.
3. Clergyman flings open the door with a poker: "Surrender!"

THE MYSTERY:
The room is completely empty. No sign of anybody, yet the housekeeping money is gone.

"Extraordinary affair!"

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The Haunted Furniture Episode

THE INVESTIGATION: Landlord and wife find Griffin's door wide open, bed cold, bandages lying about.

THE ATTACK:

- A sudden sniff close to Mrs. Hall's ear.
- The hat leaps from the bedpost into her face.
- The bedroom chair springs into the air, charges at them, pushes them out, and slams/locks the door.

THE REACTION: Mrs. Hall falls into hysterics, convinced the room is haunted by spirits or witchcraft.

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Suspicion Reaches a Boiling Point

Clergyman's Burglary

Sudden Cash

Mysterious Appearance

THE EVIDENCE:
The village links the clergyman's burglary to Griffin suddenly producing ready cash (despite claiming he had none earlier).

THE CONFRONTATION:
Mrs. Hall demands answers:

- "What have you been doing to my chair?"
- "How did you come out of an empty room?"

THE RESPONSE: The quick-tempered scientist becomes furious.

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The Headless Reveal

The Outburst: Griffin shouts: “You don’t understand who or what I am! Very well — I’ll show you.”

The Unmasking: In under a minute, he throws off his bandages, whiskers, spectacles, and false nose. The horrified bar patrons find themselves staring at a headless man!

Enter Jaffers: Constable Mr. Jaffers arrives with a magistrate’s warrant, determined to arrest a man—with or without his head.

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The Final Struggle and Escape

The Brawl

- Griffin sheds garments one by one, becoming increasingly invisible.
- Bystanders try to help but are hit by unseen blows.
- Constable Jaffers makes a desperate last attempt to hold him but is knocked unconscious.

The Result

Nervous cries of ‘Hold him!’ ring out, but Griffin shakes himself free. He is invisible once again, and no one knows where to lay hands on him.

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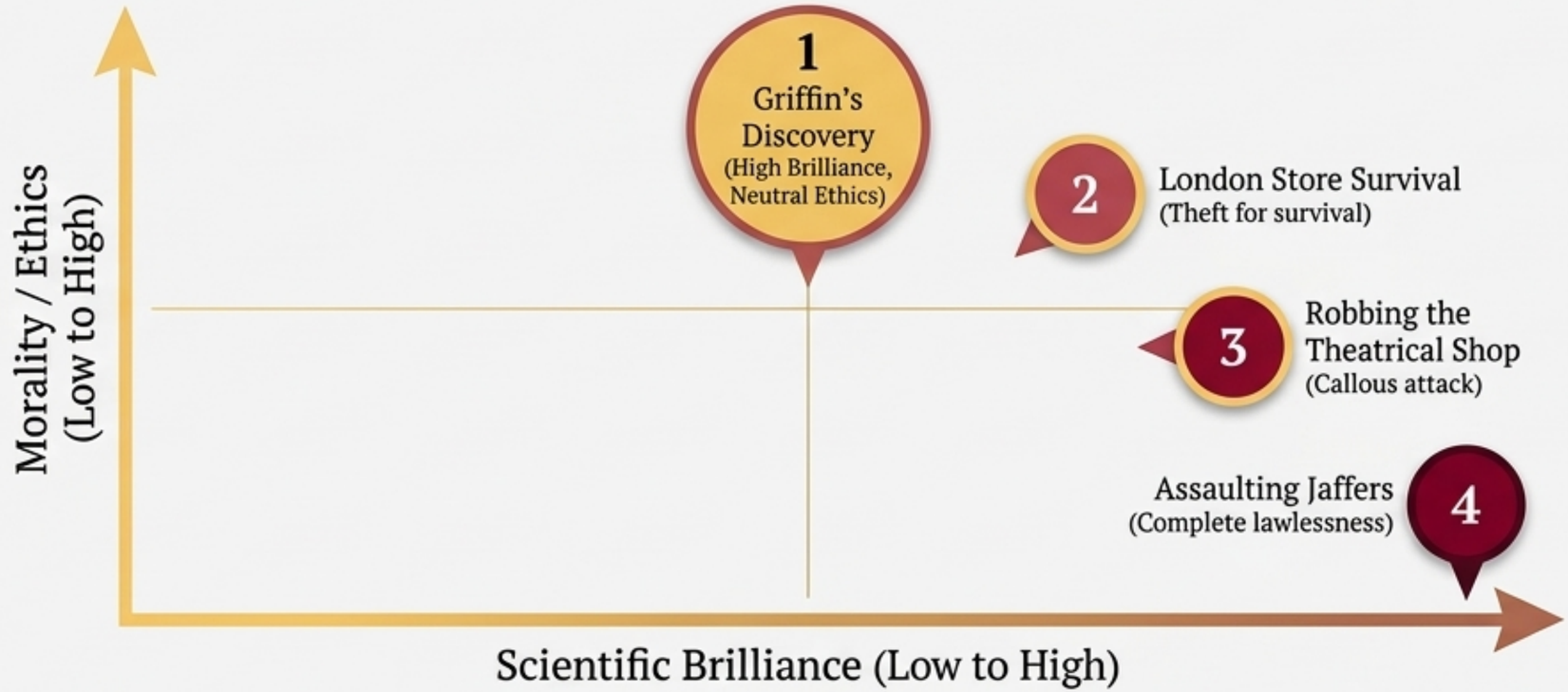
Case-File

Super Revision: Character Synthesis



CORE THEME: True scientific advancement requires an equal measure of moral responsibility. Without it, genius becomes a destructive, lawless force.

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Important Vocabulary

Case-File Evidence Log		
Word	**Meaning**	**Story Context**
Bewildered	Highly confused	The two boys seeing footprints appear from nowhere.
Eject	Force or throw out	The landlord trying to throw Griffin out of the house.
Callously	Cruelly, without sympathy	How Griffin attacked the theatrical shopkeeper.
Eccentric	Strange or unusual	Mrs. Hall's assessment of Griffin's personality.
Hysterics	Wild, uncontrollable emotion	Mrs. Hall's reaction to the flying chair.

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Board Exam Booster: Key Questions

Griffin was rather a lawless person. Comment.

Focus on him burning the house for revenge, robbing the shopkeeper, stealing from the clergyman, and fighting the law (Jaffers).

How would you assess Griffin as a scientist?

Brilliant in intellect (invented an impossible drug), but a failure as a scientist because he misused his discovery for personal gain and chaos rather than helping humanity.

Does he use or misuse his discovery?

Total misuse. The story serves as a warning about science completely divorced from human empathy and societal laws.

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